

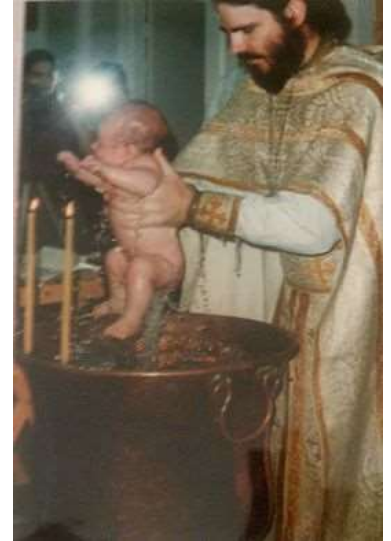
The relationship of baptism, freedom, and the commandments.

If we struggle to follow the commandments baptism makes us capable of achieving true freedom.

"A Little bit" 2018-05-11

Perhaps this "little bit" about baptism¹ is not "little", but it illustrates an important dogma which I've preached about literally hundreds of times. When I learned about Orthodoxy, I was amazed and overwhelmed with joy in seeing that the church emphatically states that we can become perfectly free, and not just be forgiven our sins. The Lord indeed promised us that we would be "free indeed", and all of our struggles to follow the commandments are **because of pursuit of this (promised) freedom**.

The West, (that is, those in the West who consider themselves to be Christian but are not Eastern Orthodox or Roman Catholic), thinks our emphasis on struggling to follow the commandments is something that is unnecessary, and even some kind of legalism. In our lax age, we even find Orthodox Christians who do not struggle to live a virtuous life. The church thinks of works (that is the struggle to follow the commandments) as a *natural response* to the freedom that is given us in baptism, and the result of a heart that is yearning to follow God and to love Him and to be *truly* free. Baptism gives us the capability of achieving true freedom. This is the exact reason why we struggle to follow the commandments and emphasize them so much. Those outside the church, and even some that were in the church and were captivated by Western legalistic theology do not understand the relationship between works and baptism and freedom. The following quote, from Abba Mark, in the wonderful book the "Evergetinos", teaches this relationship.



Perhaps some of the things Abba Mark says will seem complicated, but please, read him attentively, and then perhaps, the explanation, given via the endnotes (I advise you to read them along with the text) will help you see how profound and beautiful is the relationship that is between baptism and freedom and the following of the commandments. Unworthy, and grateful, sinful Christian and [Priest Seraphim](#)

The Evergetinos: A Complete Text, the Third Book, Hypothesis 11, paragraphs 6-10, "From Abba Mark"

6. If, then, we have been buried with Christ in baptism (Romans 6:4), and **"he that is dead is freed from sin"**² (Romans 6:7), and sin no longer reigns in us, we ought to carry out all of the commandments, so that we might **acquire the perfection given to us through baptism**³. If we fail to do this, we are faithless; for faith consists not only in being baptized into Christ, but also in fulfilling His commandments⁴. If, therefore, we neglect His commandments and pursue pleasures by our own free choice, we are, naturally, ruled by sin, thus returning, like a dog, to our own vomit (2 Peter 2:22), as the Scripture says.

7. **For in baptism man is set free by the gift of Christ, not in such a way that it carries him along by force, but so that he is able to perform the works of freedom (that is, the virtues), if he so wills.**⁵ However, according to his own will, he abides where his love lies⁶, even if he has been baptized, since his free will is not subject to constraint. For neither God nor Satan violates a man's personal will after baptism. Therefore, when Scripture says that "the violent take the kingdom of heaven by force" (Matthew 11:12), it is referring to our own will, meaning that each of us should force his own will, after baptism, not to turn towards even but to cleave to what is good. For, if we were under compulsion from demonic powers, it would certainly be possible for God, who has freed us, to force us not to incline towards evil⁷.

8. But this, in fact is not the case. Rather, God has delivered us, through baptism, from the compulsion of servitude, for He annulled sin through the cross and **laid down for us commandments that give us freedom**⁸. Whether or not we transgress those commandments depends by God's leave, on our own will. In so far as we fulfill the commandments, we signify the extent of our love for the one Who as freed us; insofar as we disregard or violate them, we demonstrate our attachment to the pleasures of life.

9. Therefore, with regard to those who say, "we want to fulfill the commandments but are unable to do so, since we are under the sway of sin even after baptism", let them know that the reason why they again become subject, even after baptism, the influence of evil is not that the holy baptism is imperfect and does not bestow complete freedom from sin and the capacity to carry out all the commandments. For "the law of the Spirit of life hath made me free from the law of sin and death (Romans 8:2); that is, it has given us complete deliverance from sin⁹.

10. It is up to us whether we bind ourselves again to sin through an inclination towards evil or remain free by fulfilling the commandments. If a sin, that is, an evil thought, holds a man's mind in captivity even though one detests that sin (this does happen and I do not deny it), nonetheless this is a remnant of Adam's sin but the result of our violating the commandments after baptism. When, after baptism, we are capable of fulfilling all the commandments but fail to perform them, then, even if unwillingly, we are held in the grip of sin, until we entreat God through repentance, by living in accordance with all of his commandments – in which case He will obliterate our sin of violating the commandments¹⁰.

Tags: A Little bit; Baptism; Freedom; The Commandments; Struggle; Priest Seraphim Holland

Source: <http://www.orthodox.net/a-little-bit/alb-baptism-freedom-and-the-commandments.pdf>

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The Orthodox Christian faith is full of life-giving truth, but it is also very complex and even overwhelming to beginners. It is not at all like the typical Western expression of Christianity, and this is part of the reason why it is so overwhelming and seems too big to many people. These small postings are in attempt to give "A Little Bit" of knowledge and edification regarding Orthodox Christianity. Since they come from my mind, they are not necessarily organized, but they are absolutely from the heart. It may be very hard to learn all the fasting rules and to go to long services and to read the Fathers, or even the Bible, but it is not so hard to read or listen to or watch a short video about something that is just "A Little Bit" about Christianity. Please send suggestions for other topics, and comments. [Priest Seraphim Holland, seraphim@orthodox.net](mailto:seraphim@orthodox.net) who is learning a little bit each day about how to be a real Christian.

¹ The baptism of Daniel Holland, <http://www.orthodox.net/daniel/baptism-daniel.jpg>

² The Apostle Paul teaches that when we are baptized we die to the old self and come out of the water a new creature. The old self was enslaved to sin, and the new creature is free from sin. This freedom is in germinal form after baptism. We have the capability to be completely free, just as an intelligent child has the capability to learn advanced mathematics. If that intelligent child never studies advanced mathematics, or is very lazy, he will never learn it despite his intelligence. So, it is with virtue. Baptism gives us the ability to become completely virtuous. We will realize this ability with struggle and God's grace.

³ Please re-read endnote one.

⁴ It is critical for anybody who was baptized or who has a child baptized understands that in accepting baptism we are making a solemn promise to God. One should never make a promise to God and then not attempt to fulfill it – this is to be faithless. In our terrible age, people think of baptism as a social event or a requirement based upon the tradition of their family, almost as a "one-off" event. The truth is, baptism is the beginning of leading a virtuous life. If anyone enters into baptism or has a child baptized without the intention of teaching or learning or teaching their child about the commandments and about all that is good and righteous, then they are faithless. This is what St. Mark is trying to say. It is clearly faithless for a person to, for instance, baptize a child and then rarely or almost never go to church, and to not teach the child about Christian virtue, and the holy Scriptures, and fasting and all of the things that are part of a life that struggles to follow the commandments.

⁵ I have made this definition of freedom literally hundreds of times in sermons. To me, it is the most beautiful thing about the Christian faith. In this life we are called to struggle for virtue. If we struggle, no matter if we fall while struggling, God's grace will assist us, and enlighten as bear us upwards, and eventually, we will be totally free ("ye shall be FREE INDEED" John 8:36). The world's definition of freedom is that a person can do whatever they want whenever they want to do it. The Christian church's definition of freedom is that we would be able to do what is good without that great effort that is sometimes necessary in this world. The Christian conception of freedom is the ability to always do good and also the ability to never do bad. This is a compelling promise.

⁶ The Lord taught this dogma very clearly: "Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves break through and steal: (20) But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break through nor steal: (21) For **where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.**" Mat 6:19-21

⁷ baptism removes that compulsion from demonic powers. Without baptism, we would be incapable of becoming virtuous. Although the devil wants to force us to sin, baptism does not allow him to do this. God never wants to force us to do anything. That would be a direct contradiction of love. God never forces us to be virtuous, but He will help us when we struggle to be virtuous.

⁸ Abba Mark's statement, that the **commandments give us freedom**, illustrates a fundamental difference between the theology of the West and of the East. In the West, the commandments were thought to be things that God decreed and that were required in order to be saved. There was rebellion against this in the so-called "Reformation", and the reformers and those that followed them correctly understood that salvation is not dependent on our following all of the commandments, but they retained the idea that the commandments were something imposed by God, and did not understand, as the church understands that the commandments are instructions to lead us to freedom, and that attempting to follow them is absolutely critical to our salvation.

⁹ Any Christian who struggles to follow the commandments will candidly admit that there are definitely times that they do not feel very "free" to follow them. These feelings are not a contradiction of Abba Mark's teaching, but rather a recognition of our own weakness. It is not Baptism that is weak, but we were baptized as weak. They feel constrained by their passions and their habits and their sins. This is one reason why the prayers of the Orthodox Church are so filled with expressions of repentance. These expressions come from the heart that knows that we can be free but also feels the pull of sin.

¹⁰ This relationship between knowing that we are sinners and knowing that God is merciful is something that is only learned by experience. The Christian who struggles to follow the commandments and fails will learn God is truly merciful by experience. Our victory is assured, as long as we try.